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THE COMEBACK KING

I WAS dropped after the 2003 World Cup. I wasn't shocked. I hadn't done well with the bat in the tournament. Still, I made a comeback against India a year later. The comeback knock, 80 off 58 balls in a 138-run opening partnership off 19 overs with Yasir Hameed, will always be special.

That 2004 tour by India was a test of Pakistani hospitality and warmth. We all passed it and passed it well. Inzi and Sachin came together to shoot ads for fighting polio. The Indian team got a standing ovation in Karachi at the end of the first ODI, which they won off the last ball. Even I toned down my famous 'For India only' sledging. General Pervez Musharraf, president of Pakistan at the time, had the visiting side over for tea at his official residence. The Pakistan press loved the Indian squad. Moreover, India were on a winning spree – a 2–1 victory in the Test series and 3–2 result in the ODIs. It was a competitive tour by all accounts.

Just five years earlier, Pakistan and India had almost gone to war, and here we were, handing out commemorative T-shirts to the Indians. I even had them over at my house for dinner but committed an oversight only a Pashtun host can – there were no vegetarian options on the menu, just tons of meat everywhere. Thankfully, we reined in the crisis and managed to get some daal and palak ready for them in no time.

It was a joyous gathering, but a year earlier, things hadn't been as upbeat when I was dropped from the side. That was a rough time. Being dropped from the team after seeing so much early success and adulation wasn't easy. Nor was staying away from international cricket for twelve months. To be honest, I hadn't performed and deserved the boot. It was quite obvious after our dismal performance at the 2003 World Cup that some of us were not going to receive fresh contracts.

I wasn't worried though, because I knew I needed to improve. Therefore I didn't sit idle at home. I played whenever and wherever I could. It's the Pathan way – always be on the hunt for prey, big or small. Never wait around to scavenge for leftovers.

I went to South Africa and was lucky enough to be coached by Mickey Arthur at Kimberly.